Country Profile: Azerbaijan

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 5
- Official language: Azerbaijani
- Official religion: None
- Plurality religion: Twelver Shia
- Core group: Azeris

Historical Background

Azerbaijan was incorporated into the Russian Empire in the 19th century. After the Russian Revolution of 1917, Azerbaijan declared independence as the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic in 1918, but in 1920 Azerbaijan became part of the Soviet Union after the Red Army invasion. Following the Soviet Union's collapse, Azerbaijan's Supreme Council adopted the Declaration of Independence on August 30, 1991. This move was formalized on October 18, 1991, with the Constitutional Act on State Independence, establishing Azerbaijan as an independent state. The early years of independence were tumultuous, marked by internal political instability, economic difficulties, and an ongoing war with Armenia over Nagorno-Karabakh. In 1994, Azerbaijan lost control over Nagorno-Karabakh. While international law recognizes it as part of Azerbaijan, the region was *de facto* controlled by the breakaway Republic of Artsakh from 1991 to 2020.[1] More recent history since 2020 falls beyond the scope of this dataset.

Groups[2]

- **Azerbaijanis, or Azeris**, are the core ethnic group in Azerbaijan, comprising over 90% of the population.[3] They primarily speak the Northern Azerbaijani variant of the Azerbaijani macrolanguage, with a small minority speaking Southern Azerbaijani, mainly descendants from Iran and Iraq.[4] Following the 1994 ceasefire in the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict, Azerbaijan saw an influx of approximately

[1] UCDP, 2024.
[2] Arda, 2024.
[3] State Statistical Committee of the Republic of Azerbaijan, 2019.
[4] Ethnologue, 2024.

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250,000 Azeri refugees from Armenia.[5] Azeris are predominantly followers of Twelver Shia Islam, the historically dominant religion in the country, despite a rise in atheism during the Soviet period.[6]

- **Lezgins** are one of the largest ethnic groups in Azerbaijan, comprising 2% of the population and historically residing in the northern regions, close to the border with Russia.[7] They speak the Lezgi language, but members of the group also commonly use Northern Azerbaijani and Russian. The majority of Lezgins adhere to Sunni Islam. According to the Self-Determination Movements database, Lezgins were involved in a self-determination movement between 1991 and 2004.[8] In 1992, the Russian organization Sadval was founded to advocate for Lezgin rights, including the creation of a single Lezgin state by redrawing the Russian-Azerbaijani border. In contrast, a more moderate organization in Azerbaijan, called Samur, sought increased cultural autonomy for Lezgins within Azerbaijan.
- **Talysh** people mostly reside in the south-eastern regions of Azerbaijan, particularly in the Lankaran and Astara districts. They comprise approximately 1.3% of the population.[9] Talysh are predominantly rural people who are mostly bilingual in Northern Azeri and Talysh, a north-western Iranian language.[10] The absolute majority of the group members are adherents of Shia Islam. The Talysh had an active self-determination movement in 1993. In June 1993, amid political turmoil and military setbacks in the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict, Ali Akhram Hummatov declared the Talysh-Mugansk Republic. However, it lasted only until August, when Heydar Aliyev took power in Baku, reasserting central control and leading to Hummatov's arrest.[11]
- **Armenians** primarily reside in the Nagorno-Karabakh region, but after losing *de facto* control over the area, many relocated to Baku. The exact number of Armenians is unclear due to the disputed status of Nagorno-Karabakh. Official estimates suggest no more than 200 Armenians live in government-controlled areas, although they make up 1.4% of the total population (approximately 120,300

[5] UNHCR, 2009.
[6] Arda, 2024.
[7] State Statistical Committee of the Republic of Azerbaijan, 2019.
[8] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[9] State Statistical Committee of the Republic of Azerbaijan, 2019.
[10] Minority rights, 2018c.
[11] Minority Rights, 2018c.

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people) when including Nagorno-Karabakh.[12] They primarily speak the Eastern Armenian language [13] and adhere to the Armenian Apostolic Church. The relationship between Armenians and Azerbaijanis has been marked by conflict, especially over the Nagorno-Karabakh region, leading to significant hostilities and displacement. During the late 1980s and early 1990s, escalating violence resulted in many Armenians fleeing Azerbaijan. Today, the Armenian population in Azerbaijan is very small, mainly due to the ongoing conflict and historical tensions between the two communities.

- **Russians** in Azerbaijan comprise around 1.3% of the population.[14] Russian is the language of their common ancestry, serving as the lingua franca in the country.[15] The majority of Russians in Azerbaijan follow the Russian Orthodox Church, although a large portion is also non-religious.[16] During the Soviet era, the Russian population in Azerbaijan increased significantly due to transmigration policies, but many Russians left after the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. Despite the decline in numbers, the Russian community continues to contribute to Azerbaijan's cultural and social landscape, maintaining their language, traditions, and religious practices.

State Profile

Official Language

The 1991 Constitutional Act of the Republic of Azerbaijan on the restoration of state independence stipulated that the 1978 Constitution would remain partially in force until a new constitution was adopted.[17] Article 73 of the 1978 Constitution of the Azerbaijan SSR designated Azerbaijani as the official state language.[18] This status was reaffirmed in the 1995 Constitution of independent Azerbaijan. During the Soviet period, Azerbaijan used the Cyrillic script; however, after gaining independence, the country began transitioning to the Latin script. A presidential decree, "On Improving the Use of the State Language," mandated that, starting from August 1, 2001, all print publications, including

[12] Minority Rights, 2024; State Statistical Committee of the Republic of Azerbaijan, 2019.
[13] Ethnologue, 2024.
[14] State Statistical Committee of the Republic of Azerbaijan, 2019.
[15] Ethnologue, 2024.
[16] Joshua Project, 2024.
[17] Constitutional Act, 1991.
[18] Kuznetsov, 2015.

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newspapers, magazines, and official documents in government agencies and private firms, be written exclusively in the Latin script.[19] In 2019, president Aliev signed a Decree "On Measures to Protect the Purity of the Azerbaijani Language and Further Improve the Use of the State Language", which introduced a slightly modified Latin script.[20]

Official Religion

The majority of Azerbaijanis adhere to Shia Islam, specifically the Twelver Ja'fari school of thought, which is the predominant branch of Shia Islam in the country. However, independent Azerbaijan's constitutional articles unambiguously proclaim the state's secular character. The 1991 Constitutional Act declared Azerbaijan to be an "independent, secular, and democratic state," and the 1995 Constitution established the separation of church and state and the equality of all religions under the law. [21]

Education Policies

The education system in Azerbaijan is structured similarly to many other countries, with compulsory education followed by optional stages of higher education. The education system consists of non-compulsory preschool education for children aged 3 to 6, compulsory primary education for children aged 6 to 11, and secondary education, which is divided into two stages: lower secondary education (grades 5 to 9) and upper secondary education (grades 10 to 11).[22]

Private schools can legally operate in Azerbaijan as of 1992.[23] The State is obligated to ensure the development of all educational institutions, including private educational institutions, by giving them credits, allocating grants, and granting concessions to state educational institutions in accordance with the legislation. [24] The school system in Azerbaijan has not been segregated on the basis of gender, race, religion, or ethnicity.

Language Education Policies

Azerbaijani is the official language of instruction in Azerbaijan, as established by the Educational Laws of 1992 and 2009.[25] Instruction in other languages may be permitted

[19] Enelane, 2017.
[20] 1news.az, 2019.
[21] Constitutional Act, 1991; Constitution of Azerbaijan, 1995.
[22] Scolaro Database, 2024.
[23] Republic of Azerbaijan, 2009.
[24] Republic of Azerbaijan, 2009.
[25] Republic of Azerbaijan, 2009.

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under specific circumstances, such as international agreements or by arrangement with relevant executive authorities. In such cases, Azerbaijani language, literature, history, and geography must still be taught according to state educational standards.[26]

The Azeri constitution guarantees that every child has the right to receive education in his or her mother tongue (Article 45). However, only the **Russian** minority has a complete system of education in their mother tongue, encompassing primary and secondary schools as well as higher education institutions. In Azerbaijan, Russian-language education is provided in 22 schools and 356 schools with Russian sectors, serving nearly 117,000 students, a number that considerably surpasses the total Russian population in the country.[27]

Lezgi is taught in 88 schools in Gusar, where instruction continues up to the 11th grade. While Lezgi has been taught in Gusar since Soviet times, its teaching in other regions like Quba is more recent and limited to primary schools (grades 1 to 4).[28]

The teaching of the **Talysh** language during the independence period began in the 1992–1993 school year, in accordance with the Decree of the President of the Republic of Azerbaijan dated September 16, 1992. At that time, the teaching of Talysh was intended to be compulsory for two hours per week in schools, namely in primary education in the regions densely populated by the Talysh. Later, the compulsory lessons were replaced with elective classes offered on a voluntary basis, one hour per week, under instructions from the Ministry of Education of the Republic of Azerbaijan.[29]

Armenian is a language of instruction in the Nagorno-Karabakh region of the Azerbaijan Republic, and no sources have been found for elective language classes in primary or secondary schools in other parts of Azerbaijan.[30]

Religious Education Policies

Azerbaijan's constitution guarantees the separation of religion and state, ensuring that the public education system remains secular.[31] As a result, religious education is not included in the official curriculum of public schools. However, public schools do offer

[26] Ibid.
[27] Kyzı, 2020.
[28] CIMERA, 2020.
[29] Statement by the Talysh Public Council of Azerbaijan, 2020.
[30] Huseynzadeh, 2020.
[31] Constitution of Azerbaijan, 1995.

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some basic understanding of world religions through a "Life Knowledge" course.[32] For more in-depth religious education, such as learning about Islam or other religions, students can attend madrasas or take special courses at churches and synagogues outside the public school system. Additionally, political parties and religious institutions are prohibited from conducting activities within educational institutions, including educational management and other related bodies.[33]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence and Forced Relocations

In 1989, there were some 400,000 **Armenians** in Azerbaijan. Around one-third of the Armenian population was resident in the enclave of Nagorno-Karabakh, and there were also significant Armenian communities in industrial centers such as Baku and Sumqayit. Following the escalation of tensions over the Nagorno-Karabakh issue and pogroms against Armenians in Baku and Sumqayit, an estimated 300,000 Armenians left the country. By the mid-1990s, reports suggested that roughly 18,000 Armenians remained in Azerbaijan, while no reliable figures were available for the Armenian population in Nagorno-Karabakh.[34]

Hrant Mikaelyan notes the estimates for the total Karabakh war dead typically range between 20,000 and 30,000.[35] The Armenian portion of the dead, including 5,865 fighters and 1,264 civilians, is fairly well accounted for in the official Armenian Encyclopedia and published on the site of the Karabakh War Museum in Stepanakert.[36]

Bans and Restrictions

There are various bans and restrictions on the use of language and religious expression in Azerbaijan. The list of banned names was first created in 2015 and is drafted by the Commission of Terminology, which operates alongside the Cabinet of Ministers. The Commission claims that it only bans names that arouse ridicule and humiliation. However, it does not provide any explanation as to why specific names are chosen. These bans have been applied to Armenian, Russian, Talysh, and Lezgi names as well.

[32] Huseynov, 2020.
[33] Republic of Azerbaijan, 2009.
[34] Minority Rights, 2024.
[35] Sanamyan, 2020.
[36] Ibid.

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Before 2001, media was available mainly in Azerbaijani, Russian, and English. Minority newspapers in Lezgin, Kurdish, and Georgian languages existed but were only printed in the regions where there were higher concentrations of these ethnic groups.[37]

On June 25, 2002, Azerbaijan's National Council for Television and Radio adopted regulations on the use of the state language (Azerbaijani) in television and radio broadcasts. The council ruled that a minimum of 75% of all programs, announcements, and advertisements on both state-controlled and privately owned television and radio stations must be in Azerbaijani.[38]

Azerbaijan's National Television and Radio Council banned international radio stations from broadcasting on national frequencies in 2009, but this applied to the BBC, Voice of America, and RFE/RL's Azeri-language service, Radio Azadliq, not necessarily the languages of ethnic minorities.[39] Although certain exceptions have been made for Russian newspapers and daily broadcasts, dubbing in the state language is mandatory. These measures restricted the flow of information in non-Azeri languages, but they did not primarily target the languages of national minorities.

Azerbaijan also instituted a ban on wearing religious symbols and clothing in 2011; restrictions on accessing places of worship have been in force since 2009, and restrictions on conversion and proselytizing since 1992. These bans and restrictions predominantly affect the adherents of Shia and Sunni Muslim groups.

More specifically, since 2011, there has been a ban on wearing the hijab in schools and an unofficial ban on wearing the hijab in the workplace. The law prohibits the use of headscarves in passport photos.[40] The 1992 legislation on religious freedom prohibits proselytizing by foreigners, while permitting citizens to do so. Those found guilty of violating this restriction, including stateless individuals, can be sentenced to one to two years in prison. This rule applies equally across all religious groups.[41]

In May 2009, police closed or tore down mosques in various Baku neighborhoods for reasons ranging from electricity repairs to alleged construction irregularities. More closures were reported in 2016. The enforced closure of Qobustan's Omar bin Khattab

[37] IREX, 2001.
[38] Azerbaijan: New Language Requirements for TV, Radio Broadcasting, compiled by Catherine Cosman, 2003.
[39] Sindelar, 2008.
[40] Adilgizi, 2022; Bashirov, 2020; US Department of State, 2022.
[41] US Department of State, 2022; Republic of Azerbaijan, 1992c.

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mosque came just days after the state forcibly closed the Lezgin Mosque in Baku's Old City. The Mosque was closed on the excuse that "repairs" were needed. Earlier in July, a Sunni Mosque in a village in the northern Quba Region was ordered to close for all activity except Friday prayers. A Shia Mosque in Baku's Old City was also ordered closed for "repairs" at the same time as the Lezgin Mosque.[42] While the justifications provided for closure are not associated with the right to religious practice (or absence thereof), such efforts clearly indicate discrimination even if they do not qualify formally as bans or legal restrictions.

Constitutions and Laws

Azerbaijan's constitutional evolution between 1991 and 2020 involves several key legal documents. After gaining independence, Azerbaijan adopted the 1991 Constitutional Act on the restoration of state independence, which had an interim character. This Act declared the separation from the Soviet Union by nullifying the accession agreement and asserting that the 1978 Constitution would remain partially in force until the adoption of a new Constitution. The 1978 Constitution included provisions on the state language and religious liberty. The 1995 Constitution then became the foundational legal document, followed by significant amendments in 2002, 2009, and 2016. The 1995 Constitution, along with these amendments, established Azerbaijani as the official state language and explicitly affirmed the separation of church and state. Notably, none of these documents specifically reference any ethnic groups or religious denominations.

Citizenship Laws

According to the law, all ethnic groups in Azerbaijan have equal access to citizenship. However, under the fears of foreign intervention after Russia's takeover of Crimea in 2014, citizenship policy in Azerbaijan became much more restrictive. This shift reflected the overall repressive turn in the country's political situation. A number of amendments to the 1998 Citizenship Law abolished unconditional *ius soli* citizenship (by territory), made concealing dual citizenship a crime, and listed many causes for the automatic loss of citizenship. Such causes include voluntary acquisition of foreign citizenship, service in a foreign army, anti-state activity, terrorism, and religious extremism. Amendments to the

[42] Forum 18, 2016.

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Constitution allowed for the deprivation of citizenship and delegated all matters of citizenship to the President.[43]

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Azerbaijan is called "Azərbaycan Marşı" [The March of Azerbaijan]. It holds a significant place in the country's national identity and reflects the pride and aspirations of the Azerbaijani people. The lyrics of the anthem were written by Ahmad Javad, a prominent Azerbaijani poet, in 1919, and the text is only available in the North Azerbaijani language. The anthem was officially adopted in 1992, shortly after Azerbaijan regained its independence after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. The lyrics of "Azərbaycan Marşı" express themes of patriotism, national pride, and the dedication of the Azerbaijani people to their homeland. It celebrates the country's history and culture, and the resilience of its people. Explicit references are made to ancestors, heroic deeds in the past, martyrdom, and military regalia. The anthem mentions the great land and its children who are heroes; it refers to thousands of lives that have been sacrificed and a land that has become a battlefield. These are clear military references and mentions of heroic deeds. The line "We are ready to be martyred for you. We are ready to shed blood for you" also cites martyrdom. The phrase "every devoted soldier has become a hero" contains allusions to the heroic deeds of the past.[44]

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[43] Tabachnik, 2019.

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